

Thirty-six years old, married, one wife, no children. No formal education. No previous job. Bought khoka for £80 one year ago, has a canoe, employs fifteen labourers paid £2 per month. Owns fifteen-acre farm growing cotton, maize, cassava, millet, and employing labourers. Owns eighteen cattle, fifteen goats, forty chickens. Also owns a cart. Has £200 saved. Income last year £400; next year expects £900. Present catch rate would give income over £800. "People get richer by working harder than others."

Fischer A.

APPENDIX: EXAMPLES OF "BIG" FISHERMEN

Furthermore, as fishing increases in scale, so does the probability of extension of the scale of business, with fishermen processing and selling their own catches. One of the biggest Chilwa fishermen once owned a truck bought for trading (both his own catches and those of others), but during the lake recession he lost money and, subsequently, the truck. On Lake Malawi a number of successful fish traders have bought nets and boats and have employed as many as thirty men (Williams 1969). The fish trader survey currently underway at Chilwa has discovered a few such entrepreneurs. Given the previous description of how the big fishermen have diversified their economic activities, it might be considered an expected step to enter the fish trading business as well. Already (in 1972) it has been reported that a number of the larger-scale fishermen sell their fish directly to large concerns exporting to Zambia and Rhodesia rather than to local traders. It will bear watching to see whether some of these big fishermen will move into the trading business on their own.

We have given but a sketch of the small group of entrepreneur-fishermen on Lake Chilwa and emphasised the need for further enquiry. But some basic facts have been charted. These big fishermen (and "big" is relative to the area, for on Lake Malawi, for example, there are much larger commercial fishing companies) are a very small minority. They have been able to exploit the opportunity fishing has presented of a much higher income than the average for Malawi. They have done this by investing in innovations such as the shore seine with the high catch rate, by long hours at the lake, and by determination even in the face of a recurrent recession of lake waters. Their success in fishing is also closely linked with large farms, cattle keeping and the running of small businesses. This diversification has effectively spread the risks of investment in an economically unstable environment. We have seen that a large initial capital has not been necessary in the past and that many fishermen have worked their way up to success gradually. However, since most recent improvements in fishing are expensive (such as shore seines, motorised boats, the more efficient ways of processing fish, and the like), the emphasis on capital is bound to increase.

SNOUT-NOSE

considered valid enough to use as the basis of the distinction between the more and the less successful fishermen, more enquiry is needed on the amount of its sources, its relation to various investments, and to expenditure, as well to factors such as social standing.